

Thursday, 18 June 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Overcast 28° 18°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 24° 16°	MANCHESTER Light drizzle 23° 15°	GLASGOW Light rain 17° 14°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

The high-stakes Makerfield by-election is reaching its climax today, with candidates making their final push for votes.

This contest is seen as crucial and could potentially influence who becomes the next Prime Minister. All eyes are on the results to see if there's a shift in political landscape.

POLITICS · UK
- 2

A British couple has described the 'surreal' experience of having warning shots fired near them by a Russian warship in the English Channel.

The retired couple told Newsnight they were trying to show the warship they had changed course when the shots were fired. It's certainly an alarming incident for British waters.

INTERNATIONAL · UK
- 3

Abuse was hurled at a judge as the first group of rioters were sentenced following the Ely disorder last year.

The violence and vandalism in 2023 was sparked by the deaths of teenagers Kyrees Sullivan and Harvey Evans. This marks the beginning of the legal process for those involved.

CRIME · UK
- 4

Prince Harry and Meghan are reportedly bringing their children to the UK next month.

This will be the first time the Duke of Sussex has brought his children to the UK in four years. It's expected to be a significant visit for the family.

ROYALS · UK
- 5

Kensington Palace has announced that Prince George will follow in his father's footsteps at Eton College.

The young prince is set to attend the elite boarding school from September. This continues a long-standing royal tradition.

ROYALS · UK

What's coming up

- 1 A West End theatre is set to be renamed in honour of the legendary Dame Judi Dench.**
The Shaftesbury Theatre will be renamed to recognise Dame Judi's immense contribution to the performing arts over her illustrious career. It's a wonderful tribute to a national treasure.
ON AIR – What's your favourite Dame Judi Dench role, on stage or screen?
THEATRE · COMING UP
- 2 Filming has begun on a new comedy from Ruth Jones and Steve Speirs, a project Jones says has been '35 years in the making'.**
The pair have been busy with other projects, but are finally bringing this long-gestating idea to life. It sounds like a real passion project for the Gavin & Stacey star.
ON AIR – What other long-awaited collaborations or projects would you love to see finally happen?
TV · COMING UP
- 3 The fifth instalment of the beloved animated franchise, Toy Story 5, has split critics but is largely praised for its 'cautionary' message.**
Tom Hanks, Tim Allen, and Joan Cusack all return to voice their iconic characters. It sounds like it's going to be another thought-provoking adventure for Woody and Buzz.
ON AIR – Are you excited for another Toy Story film, or do you think they should have left it after the last one?
FILM · COMING UP
- 4 The Grammy Awards have announced the addition of new categories, including Asian Pop and Latin song.**
This move comes after significant wins from artists like Bad Bunny and KPop Demon Hunters. It's a great step towards recognising a wider range of global music talent.
ON AIR – What other music genres do you think deserve their own Grammy categories?
MUSIC · COMING UP
- 5 British rock band The Darkness are set to feature in the new He-Man theme, alongside Queen guitarist Brian May.**
The band, from Lowestoft, will be part of the soundtrack for the new animated series. It sounds like a fantastic combination of rock legends for a classic cartoon!
ON AIR – What iconic TV show theme tune would you love to see a modern band re-imagine?
MUSIC · COMING UP

On the schedule

- 1 Lionel Messi has continued to make history at the World Cup, delivering another masterclass performance.**
While Kylian Mbappe and Erling Haaland also started strongly, Messi still took top billing on a day packed with superstars. He truly is extraordinary to watch.

ON AIR – Is Lionel Messi the greatest footballer of all time, or does someone else get your vote?

FOOTBALL · INTERNATIONAL
- 2 British number five Arthur Fery has reached the Queen's quarter-finals with a superb display.**
Fery beat Adrian Mannarino to keep home hopes alive in the HSBC Championships. It's being hailed as his 'best-ever' result, a fantastic achievement!

ON AIR – How far do you think Arthur Fery can go in the tournament?

TENNIS · UK
- 3 England captain Nat Sciver-Brunt has been ruled out of at least the next two T20 World Cup matches due to injury.**
She suffered a left calf injury on Tuesday, which is a big blow for the team. Hopefully, she'll be back on the pitch soon.

ON AIR – How much of an impact will Sciver-Brunt's absence have on England's World Cup campaign?

CRICKET · INTERNATIONAL
- 4 Jacob Bethell took a stunning diving catch to remove New Zealand captain Tom Latham at The Oval.**
The 'brilliant' catch came off the bowling of Jofra Archer, as New Zealand fell to 58-2. It was a real highlight moment in the second Test.

ON AIR – What's the best cricket catch you've ever seen?

CRICKET · UK
- 5 Former England captain Michael Vaughan says it would be a 'travesty' if Ben Stokes doesn't captain England again.**
This comes after Stokes was reportedly stripped of the Test captaincy for breaking a midnight curfew. It's certainly caused a stir in the cricket world.

ON AIR – Do you agree with Michael Vaughan, should Ben Stokes remain captain despite the curfew breach?

CRICKET · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A recent trend sees more people embracing 'wild swimming' in designated natural spots.**
Enthusiasts report improved mental well-being and a refreshing connection with nature. Safety is key, with many joining organised groups or following local guidelines.
- 2 The popularity of 'micro-gardening' in small urban spaces is on the rise.**
Even a tiny balcony or windowsill can become a productive patch for herbs, vegetables, or colourful flowers, bringing a bit of green into city living.
- 3 Research highlights the unexpected benefits of learning a new, non-digital skill.**
Whether it's knitting, pottery, or woodworking, engaging hands-on with a craft can boost creativity and provide a sense of accomplishment away from screens.
- 4 The simple pleasure of 'porch sitting' is being rediscovered across the country.**
Taking a moment to relax on a doorstep or a small stoop, watching the world go by, is proving to be a lovely way to unwind and connect with neighbours.
- 5 A new study suggests that listening to 'nature sounds' can significantly reduce stress levels.**
From birdsong to rainfall, immersing yourself in ambient nature audio has been shown to calm the mind, even if you're stuck indoors.
- 6 The trend for 'upcycled fashion' workshops is empowering people to transform old clothes.**
Instead of discarding items, participants learn creative ways to mend, alter, and redesign garments, giving them a unique second life and promoting sustainability.
- 7 Experts are noting a rise in 'community art projects' brightening public spaces.**
From vibrant murals to knitted lamp post covers, these collaborative efforts are bringing people together and adding a splash of colour and creativity to local areas.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'rehearsing' what in front of a mirror, just to make sure we've got it right?

ANSWER: A TRICKY CONVERSATION OR A SPEECH!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a specific 'mug' or 'cup' that no one else in the house is allowed to use. What is it?

ANSWER: OUR FAVOURITE ONE FOR OUR MORNING BREW!

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes a particular 'smell' can instantly transport you back to a specific memory or a moment in time?**

Maybe it's the smell of freshly cut grass reminding you of childhood summers, or a certain perfume bringing back a fond memory. What scent takes you back, and what's the story behind it?

- **We all have those little 'shortcuts' we take in life, don't we? Things we've discovered that make a task quicker, easier, or just a bit more efficient.**

Perhaps it's a clever way to peel vegetables, a trick for folding laundry, or a route you take to avoid traffic. What's your best-kept shortcut or tip that makes life a little bit smoother?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** A group of owls is called a parliament.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Baby puffins are called 'pufflings' when they are young.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£33 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£33 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The longest place name in the world is Taumatawhakatangihangakoauauotamateaturipukakapikimaungahoronukupokaiwhenuakitanatahu, located in New Zealand.
- The average cloud weighs around 550 tons, which is roughly the same as 100 elephants.
- Strawberries are the only fruit with seeds on the outside.
- A full moon is nine times brighter than a half moon.
- The world's oldest known living tree is over 5,000 years old and is a Bristlecone Pine.
- A snail can sleep for three years.
- The shortest complete sentence in the English language is 'I am'.
- Bubble wrap was originally intended to be used as wallpaper.

On this day

Day 169 of the year, 196 days left in 2026. Today Autistic Pride Day (International); Christian feast day: Bernard Mizeki (Anglican and Episcopal Church); Christian feast day: Elisabeth of Schönau; Christian feast day: Gregorio Barbarigo. Star sign Gemini, birthstone Pearl.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1987 — Moeen Ali, English cricketer
- 1973 — Ray LaMontagne, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1927 — Paul Eddington, English actor (died 1995)
- 1961 — Alison Moyet, English singer-songwriter
- 1941 — Delia Smith, English chef and author
- 1952 — Isabella Rossellini, Italian actress, director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1971 — Nigel Owens, Welsh rugby referee and TV presenter
- 1976 — Blake Shelton, American singer-songwriter and guitarist

THE DAY TODAY

- 1983 — Mona Mahmudnizhad, together with nine other women of the Bahá'í Faith, is sentenced to death and hanged in Shiraz, Iran over her religious beliefs.
- 1953 — The Egyptian revolution of 1952 ends with the overthrow of the Muhammad Ali dynasty and the declaration of the Republic of Egypt.
- 1940 — The "Finest Hour" speech is delivered by Winston Churchill.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 2018 — An earthquake of magnitude 6.1 strikes northern Osaka.
- 1983 — Space Shuttle program: STS-7, Astronaut Sally Ride becomes the first American woman in space.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1972 — Staines air disaster: One hundred eighteen people are killed when a BEA H.S. Trident crashes minutes after takeoff from London's Heathrow Airport.
- 1948 — Britain, France and the United States announce that on June 21, the Deutsche Mark will be introduced in western Germany and West Berlin. Over the next six days, Communists increasingly restrict access to Berlin.[citation needed]

- 2009 — The Lunar Reconnaissance Orbiter (LRO), a NASA robotic spacecraft is launched.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 170 of the year, 195 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Deodatus (or Didier) of Nevers (or of Jointures); Christian feast day: Gervasius and Protasius (Catholic Church); Christian feast day: Hildegrim of Châlons; Christian feast day: Juliana Falconieri. Star sign Gemini, birthstone Pearl.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 2004 — Millie Gibson, English actress
- 1972 — Robin Tunney, American actress
- 1980 — Jean Carroll, Irish cricketer
- 1970 — Brian Welch, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1975 — Hugh Dancy, English actor and model
- 1992 — Keaton Jennings, South African-English cricketer
- 1998 — Atticus Shaffer, American actor and YouTuber
- 1964 — Brian Vander Ark, American singer-songwriter and guitarist

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2007 — The al-Khilani Mosque bombing in Baghdad leaves 78 people dead and another 218 injured.
- 2009 — Mass riots involving over 10,000 people and 10,000 police officers break out in Shishou, China, over the dubious circumstances surrounding the death of a local chef.
- 1961 — Kuwait declares independence from the United Kingdom.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1990 — The Communist Party of the Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic is founded in Moscow.
- 2007 — The al-Khilani Mosque bombing in Baghdad leaves 78 people dead and another 218 injured.

Coming to cinemas

JUNE 2026

FRI 19	Pixar's Toy Story 5
FRI 26	Supergirl: Woman of Tomorrow (+ IMAX); A Private Life

JULY 2026

WED 1	Minions & Monsters
FRI 3	Shiver; Young Washington
FRI 10	Moana (live action); Evil Dead Burn
FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JUNE 2026		JULY 2026	
11 JUN – 19 JUL	FIFA World Cup (USA / Canada / Mexico)	4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
12 JUN – 5 JUL	ICC Women's T20 World Cup (England & Wales)	SUN 5	British Grand Prix, Silverstone
18–21 JUN	U.S. Open (Golf)	16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
29 JUN – 12 JUL	Wimbledon	18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
		23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
		AUGUST 2026	
		W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
		SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
		22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)